

Memo

To: Karen McDonnell

From: LeeAnne English-Stewart

Date: February 28, 2025

Subject: Project 1

I have attached the fully edited version of ‘In Our Free Society, Where’s Our Self-Expression?’, which I have retitled ‘Tattoos: The Limit to Self-Expression?’ In revising this piece I applied AP Style guidelines and our course materials to improve clarity, readability, and logical flow while maintaining the original intent of the article.

My main focus in editing this article was to create a more engaging real-world introduction, enhance the overall concision, refine the tone, and strengthen the coherence of the argument.

The following includes changes I have made to the article:

- I retitled the article from "In Our Free Society, Where’s Our Self-Expression?" to "Tattoos: The Limit to Self-Expression?" in order to better reflect the core argument and focus of the piece.
- I restructured the article to establish a stronger introduction, ensure a logical progression of ideas, eliminate repetition, create clearer paragraph transitions, and enhance the overall persuasiveness of the argument.
- I revised sentence structures to remove redundancy, making them more focused, direct, and engaging.
- I modified certain phrases to create a more natural, readable tone that aligns with *The Breeze*’s audience. For instance, I replaced "*It happens to be that our society has trained us to associate...*" with "*Society has conditioned us to associate...*"
- Overall, I removed unnecessary fillers and used more direct language to enhance clarity. For example, I revised "It happens to be that our society has trained us to associate tattoos and tattooed people as synonymous with negative characteristics." to "Society has conditioned us to associate tattoos with negative stereotypes."
- I refined the final paragraph to strengthen the case for promoting diversity and inclusion, reinforcing how American cultural biases shape perceptions of self-expression.
- I included the statement “Although one change is permanent and the other is temporary...” to demonstrate a clearer understanding of the logic behind the comparison.

I hope these edits are clear and you find them to make the piece more effective. Please let me know if you have any questions or comments about my adjustments.

Tattoos: The Limit to Self-Expression?

By Briana Ellison | The Breeze

Imagine walking into work one morning after changing your hair color. You used to be blonde, but you've decided to go bright red. As you walk to your desk your coworkers compliment the change. Someone asks why you did it and you reply, "I just felt like red hair suited me better." The conversation ends there, and people continue to praise your decision to express yourself.

Now picture a different scenario. Instead of changing your hair, you get a tattoo of a meaningful quote. Since you are excited to share something personal, you show it to a few coworkers that you feel close to. Some respond positively, but others seem uncomfortable or even judgmental. Word spreads to your boss and suddenly your tattoo—not your work ethic or professionalism—becomes a topic of discussion.

Although one change is permanent and the other is temporary, only tattoos face judgment, while dyeing your hair is socially accepted as a form of self-expression.

So, why does this contradiction exist?

Let's begin to unpack this question by defining self-expression. The Merriam-Webster Dictionary defines self-expression as "the expression of one's own personality: the assertion of one's individual traits." While this definition once referred to traditional art forms, as American culture has become more progressive we now recognize self-expression to include personal style choices as well.

As self-expression has progressed in our culture, newer forms have faced intense social scrutiny. This isn't surprising as history shows that people are quick to judge anything unfamiliar. Some forms of self-expression may be more extreme and warrant concern, but many, like tattoos, are unfairly criticized. Our culture claims to value individuality, yet tattoos remain a source of judgment and alienation. If we truly embrace self-expression, why do so many still reject it when it comes to body art?

Many people tend to dislike tattoos due to religious beliefs, personal aesthetics, or societal norms. However, personal preference should not justify discriminating against tattooed individuals based on their form of self-expression. The media plays a role in reinforcing negative stereotypes, often portraying characters with tattoos as criminals, while musicians and actors are allowed to embrace body art as part of their "brand." These stereotypes carry over into real life, where people with tattoos are unfairly seen as unprofessional. Rather than judging individuals by their character, we reduce them to misconceptions based solely on their body art.

Tattoos are often artistic, meaningful, and deeply personal. Yet one of the most common arguments against them is their permanence. Ironically, the same people who critique tattoos often praise other permanent forms of self-expression, such as painting, published writing, and music production. This contradiction reveals the hypocrisy woven into American attitudes toward self-expression.

Social conformity is deeply woven into American culture, and the stigma against tattoos as a form of self-expression reinforces this pressure to conform. At the same time, our culture encourages individuality. People often express themselves in widely accepted ways, such as through hair color, fashion, or makeup. Yet when it comes to tattoos, the same encouragement disappears. Despite promoting uniqueness, we contradict ourselves by drawing lines around acceptable self-expression. Changing your hair color is praised, but getting a tattoo? That crosses an invisible boundary. If we truly value self-expression, why do we continue to impose limits on certain forms of it?

Ultimately, this issue comes down to perspective. Disliking tattoos is one thing, but using that opinion to judge or limit others is unfair. At the same time, those with tattoos must recognize that there will always be people who oppose them. However, as long as a tattoo is not offensive or harmful, it shouldn't be a cause for discrimination. If we want to promote a culture that truly values diversity and acceptance, we must move beyond snap judgments and embrace what makes each of us unique.